

Case Study 1 - Atari

Student submission

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Worksheet link

<https://courses.ethereallab.app/assignment/v4/IT265-001-F2026/case-study-1-atari/jrm236>

Grading link

<https://courses.ethereallab.app/assignment/v4/IT265-001-F2026/case-study-1-atari/grading/jrm236>

AI disclosure: Completed; 1 entry; 0 declared AI use; 1 declared no AI use; policy v1

Game Overview

Game details

Response prompt

Identify the game: title, developer, publisher, original platform, genre, and release date. Note the version you played if different.

Submitted response

The game I chose was the 1983 canceled Atari 2600 game, Garfield. After some research, it seems the game was developed by two programmers: Steve Woita and Mimi Nyden. Since the game was canceled, there is no official release date, although the game was released online in a prototype state with permission from the creator of Garfield, Jim Davis.

History and industry

Response prompt

Explain the historical context of the release and where the game fit in the industry at that time.

Submitted response

The game was developed but never released due to the 1983 video game crash. Once Atari was sold off, the new owners looked at games they believed wouldn't perform well and decided to cut this game.

Contemporary comparison

Response prompt

Compare the game with a similar game from the same period, explaining a meaningful design similarity or difference.

Submitted response

A game that can be compared to Garfield would be the game Pitfall, which was also made for the Atari 2600. Gameplay-wise, both games are similar, in that they are both platformers where the goal is to move from one end of the screen to the other. Garfield has an obvious lack of animations and no foreseeable end, as it's just a set of four looping screens; Pitfall, on the other hand, has animation and a goal to collect a certain amount of treasure under a time limit.

Gameplay Mechanics And Level Design

Core gameplay mechanics

Response prompt

Explain how the core actions and rules shape a recurring player decision. Support the explanation with a gameplay example.

Submitted response

When starting the game, you start on what seems to be a fence. Garfield can look both left and right, duck, and jump to the next fence depending on where he looks. Other than that, you are told nothing about how the game works. After a

few seconds, burgers? fly from one end to the other; Garfield can eat these burgers to gain points. Using the controls, the player is incentivized to try moving off the screen, which takes them to the next level of the game.

Level design

Response prompt

Explain how the layout, obstacles, or progression affect a player decision or challenge. Use a specific example.

Submitted response

The level design within this game is relatively simple; each screen the player can travel to has set points that can be jumped to as Garfield, as well as certain obstacles that either give the player points or damage the player, making them lose lives. For example, in the second screen the player can move to after the fences with burgers, the player will be sent to a new area, where flower pots will fly towards the player. If these flower pots hit Garfield, he will lose a life, starting back at the beginning of the screen. As such, the player must travel to the next screen without getting hit.

Graphic And Audio Design

Visual design

Response prompt

Explain how a visual design choice affects the experience or communicates information during play. Use a specific example.

Submitted response

The visual design of the game is very simple. This game doesn't really contain any animations. The only thing that can be counted as such would be the sprites being flipped or whenever Garfield ducks to dodge a flower pot. Additionally, the general sprite work of the game was very simple. There are only a few sprites in the game, and almost all of them are reused to pad out the game. The sprites also don't really convey any immediate information to the player prior to their effect being activated. For example, when the game starts, the player doesn't know if the burgers are dangerous until they touch one and see they gain points from it, but if the player travels to the next screen and sees the flower pots, maybe they will think they are safe and try to interact with them, only to get damaged and sent back to the beginning.

Sound design

Response prompt

Explain how music, sound effects, or their absence affect the experience or communicate information during play. Use a specific example.

Submitted response

Garfield for the Atari 2600 doesn't feature any sound effects when you jump, but it utilizes simple sound effects for when the player gets hit or interacts with objects. The absence of sound in the game makes it very clear that the game was unfinished, but the little sound the game did have made it very clear what the intention of each attached object was. For example, if Garfield gets hit by a flower pot, the game makes an ear-piercing sound while resetting the character back to the start of the screen, which incentivizes the player to not get hit to avoid the sound from playing again.

Narrative And Storytelling

Narrative and setting

Response prompt

Explain how the setting and story relate to play. Describe key events if present, or explain the effect of a limited or absent story.

Submitted response

This game doesn't have any obvious story, but after a few rounds of play, the objective seems to become apparent. In the first screen of the game, Garfield starts on a fence, eating burgers while traveling to the next screen. In the second screen, Garfield must now dodge flower pots. In the third screen, we see Odie, who seems to be playing a red-light,

green-light-esque game, in which, if you are spotted, you take damage. In the final screen, we see what seems to be Nermal, who is hanging off the ledge of a roof, to which Garfield must jump to save him. After this, the game resets to the first screen with flying burgers. So it seems the goal of the game is to help Nermal while dodging all of the obstacles along the way.

Character development

Response prompt

Explain how character development relates to gameplay, or how limited or absent development affects the experience.

Submitted response

There is no character development within the game. As such, this causes the player's experience to become more confused upon starting the game. The only thing that can possibly be counted as character development is probably the fact that Garfield eats a lot to gain points, but other than that, there isn't much that constitutes character development.

Impact And Reception

Reception

Response prompt

Summarize the critical and player reception using identifiable reviews or feedback. Distinguish release-era reception from later reactions.

Submitted response

Because this game was canceled before release, it never received any formal reviews from critics or players. However, later reactions after the prototype was released were generally mixed. This was mainly due to the repetitive screen loop and limited gameplay.

Industry and cultural impact

Response prompt

Explain the game's industry impact and cultural significance using research. Avoid claiming influence that the sources do not establish.

Submitted response

As stated previously, Garfield for the Atari 2600 was canceled because it had no player reception; as such, the game also had no direct impact on the games industry. The only significance it has in history is as lost media prior to the release of the unfinished prototype.

Reflection

Fun and experience

Response prompt

Explain what made the game enjoyable or frustrating for you, using a gameplay example.

Submitted response

When playing this game, I wouldn't say I was frustrated or enjoying it, but was more intrigued about the nature of the game and how it was so confusing for me to understand what was going on at first. As I used in prior examples, the game starts immediately, and the burgers just begin flying at you from the sides of the screen. When I saw them, I initially thought they were obstacles that the player had to dodge, so I began spamming every key on my keyboard, finding out that you can duck to avoid getting hit, but not after getting hit by the flying burgers and getting points. The whole time I was playing this game, this was largely my experience: not knowing how something works or what it is, but then finding out after getting damaged or points.

Learning and research

Response prompt

Reflect on what this case study taught you and how easy or difficult it was to find dependable information.

Submitted response

This case study taught me about how older games were designed and played with the limitations of their time. In the case of Garfield in particular, it taught me about how finding dependable info about unreleased games can be very difficult, making me realize just how important preservation is for games.